



Indochinese clouded leopard

Neofelis nebulosa

While they share a name and markings that allow them to blend in with their environment, clouded leopards and other leopards are not directly related. In fact, the Indochinese clouded leopard is unique in many ways. Relative to its size, this solitary cat has the longest upper canine teeth of any living felid—around 2 in (5 cm). It also has an impressive gape of almost 100 degrees, whereas a lion's mouth, for example, only opens to an average of 65 degrees.

Short, powerful legs, broad paws, and a thick, densely furred tail that is often as long as its body make the clouded leopard an excellent climber. It is able to move along the underside of branches, run headfirst down trees, and hang upside down by its hind feet, which rotate backward courtesy of flexible ankle joints. Clouded leopards are also superb swimmers.

Secretive cat

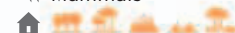
Since they are such experts at blending into their dense forest habitat, little is known about clouded leopard behavior, although males show a high degree of aggression toward females in captivity. Once believed to be nocturnal hunters, recent evidence suggests that they may hunt during the day as well, taking prey on the ground despite being such good climbers.

↔ 28–43 in (71–110 cm)

⚖ 24–51 lb (11–23 kg)

⊗ Vulnerable

🐾 Mammals



S. and SE. Asia

two conspicuous black bars on back of head and neck



◁ CLOUDED COAT

The cloudlike spots mimic a forest's dappled shade. Unlike the coat of the clouded leopard that lives in Borneo and Sumatra, the darker patches are only bordered in black on the back edge.